tice. NLU graduates have ventured into various fields. Some got admitted to top universities of the world to pursue master's and doctorate degrees, with quite a few bagging prestigious scholarships like Rhodes, Inlaks, and Chevening; joined the civil services and judiciary; worked in the development sector; and some decided to join the Bar and litigate in courts.

However, the success of NLU graduates and a few others from good law schools should not blind us to the state of hundreds of other public and private law schools nationwide that essentially represent a "sea of institutionalised mediocrity". Several law schools are plagued by problems such as a lack of resources, outdated curriculums, listless leadership, inadequate and demotivated faculty members, and a lack of academic autonomy. Even most NLUs, while successfully attracting excellent students, have failed to emerge as centres of excellence in legal research. Only two Indian law schools–Jindal Global Law School and National Law School of India University–figure in the QS [universities] rankings of the top 200 law schools worldwide.

Need for Reforms

This brings us to the reforms needed to bolster legal education in India. First, legal education requires suitable regulators. The Bar Council of India (BCI) is the key regulator of legal education. The BCI's role in regulating legal education, which pertains to acquiring basic eligibility for practicing in the courts, is indispensable. However, several other facets of legal education, especially at the post-graduation level, do not pertain to litigation. Accordingly, a Parliamentary Standing Committee on Legal Education recently recommended that regulating these parts of legal education should be entrusted to an independent body called the National Council for Legal Education and Research. This proposed body will develop qualitative benchmarks to regulate legal education.

Second, law schools need to update their curricula regularly. The legal field is dynamic and keeps changing through the enactment of new laws, novel interpretations, and evolving doctrines. The new set of criminal laws recently enacted in India is a case in point. Moreover, law schools need to develop new courses and a global curriculum given the newfangled realities and challenges ranging from climate change to the ethics of artificial intelligence.

Third, there's an urgent need to bolster legal research in our law schools. Many of India's 1,700-odd law schools principally focus on teaching with scant attention to research. Consequently, India is chiefly the consumer of legal knowledge generated in the West, not its producer. Prioritising and promoting research in legal education will lead to better teaching outcomes and help students develop a critical perspective. As Albert Einstein said, "The value of an education is not the learning of many facts but the training of the mind to think". Law schools need to make strident efforts in this direction by incentivising research and creating a research-friendly environment.

"Law schools need to develop new courses and a global curriculum given new realities and challenges such as climate change and AI"

Furthermore, our law schools should enjoy complete academic freedom and autonomy. As Jawaharlal Nehru said, "A university stands for humanism, for tolerance, for reason, for the adventure of ideas and for the search of truth". A law school or any other academic institution can accomplish this goal only if academicians are free to offer their well-researched views without any fear, even if these views are at variance with popularly held beliefs in society or contest the dominant ideas of the time.

Fourth, a major structural reform that needs to be undertaken is to convert all NLUs to full-fledged central institutions and bestow on them the status of institute of national importance (INI). As INIs, these NLUs will become truly 'national' and create new qualitative benchmarks that other law schools can aspire to. There's already a precedent for this. In 2007, the National Institute of Technology Act was enacted, which elevated the status of various regional engineering colleges to INIs. The move will also ensure the Centre provides more funds to NLUs, making an NLU degree affordable for the poor and the marginalised. Currently, most NLUs charge a fee of around three lakh rupees per annum. The high fee is due to most NLUs not getting adequate financial support from the respective state governments.

Fifth, the leadership positions in our law schools should be held by passionate, charismatic and visionary academicians who inspire and create an enabling and supportive environment that allows younger academicians to realise their potential as outstanding teachers and brilliant researchers.

However, this is only possible once higher education is everyone's top priority. Legal education is at a crossroads, and the proper state intervention can yield good results. ■

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